



**STATEMENT BY THE
PERMANENT REPRESENTATIVE OF MEXICO TO THE UN,
AMBASSADOR JUAN RAMÓN DE LA FUENTE
AT THE GENERAL DEBATE OF THE
TENTH REVIEW CONFERENCE OF THE
TREATY ON THE NON-PROLIFERATION OF
NUCLEAR WEAPONS**

- UNOFFICIAL TRANSLATION -

New York, 2 August 2022.

Mr. President,

Mexico is pleased that this Conference is being held at last, and that it is you who leads its endeavors. We recognize your tireless work to achieve this, in complex circumstances, and we reiterate our support for bringing the Conference to a successful conclusion.

I would like to begin my statement by briefly recalling some historical context that comes to mind. After the so-called missile crisis in 1962, but even from the beginning of the Cold War, Mexico could have joined the United States nuclear deterrence system. We were, besides being neighbors, a State party to the Inter-American Treaty of Reciprocal Assistance of 1948 (Treaty of Rio), the only defensive pact of the Americas.

But Mexico chose to structure the defense of its territory and the security of its population, based on international law and, above all, on the basis of the Charter of the United Nations. The International Court of Justice unequivocally established in 1996 that the use of

nuclear weapons "would generally be contrary to international law", something my country had always maintained.

Precisely for this reason, Mexico took the initiative to create the first nuclear-weapon-free zone in Latin America and the Caribbean, through the Treaty of Tlatelolco of 1967. Prior to the NPT, and for more than 70 years, my country has made countless contributions to the international disarmament regime.

The most recent of these is the 2017 Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (TPNW), logical culmination of international law and of the conviction of the General Assembly regarding the "inherently immoral" nature of nuclear weapons (res. A/76/25). This Treaty is increasingly becoming universal and Mexico will have the honor of chairing its Second Meeting of States Parties in 2023.

We come to this Conference today to reaffirm our conviction that the NPT is the cornerstone of the nonproliferation and disarmament regime. Therefore, we do not, come here to barter our support for the NPT. Its provisions must be fully implemented, in a balanced manner, and without conditions, by all its parties. The so-called *grand bargain* should not be reinterpreted, nor distorted.

It is a fact that the objectives of the NPT on nonproliferation, as well as those related to the peaceful uses of atomic energy, have been largely met. With very few exceptions, the Non-nuclear weapons States have fulfilled our part of that Great Negotiation. Some, such as Mexico, have even made additional and complementary voluntary commitments to the NPT, such as the Additional Protocol of the International Atomic Energy Agency and those derived from export control regimes and, of course, the Ban Treaty, the TPNW.

Much remains to be done to further strengthen the nuclear nonproliferation regime, such as achieving the universality of the NPT, strengthening the implementation of the safeguards system, and ensuring that more countries benefit from atomic energy for peaceful purposes, as well as guaranteeing the safety and security of nuclear facilities. We hope that this Conference will take concrete steps in these directions.

However, the great pending issue of the NPT continues to be the disarmament obligations contained in its article 6. Around 13,000 nuclear weapons remain in the arsenals of the Nuclear Weapon States, who justify their existence in Cold War military doctrines: This undermines the unequivocal undertaking to eliminate nuclear weapons assumed by Nuclear Weapons States at the 2000 Review Conference.

Mexico firmly rejects any argument that seeks to justify the continued existence of nuclear weapons and the threat of their use. Therefore, we expect, at a minimum, that the Nuclear Weapons States reaffirm their commitment to the implementation of their obligations under the NPT, and report to the Conference on their progress within deadlines and benchmarks, in order to build confidence among all States Parties.

This Conference, colleagues, is taking place in the context of the armed conflict in Ukraine in which the Russian Federation has placed its nuclear systems on high operational alert. This increases the dangers associated with their intentional or accidental use.

This is even less comprehensible since the Nuclear Weapon States, in preparation for this Conference, had rightly reaffirmed on 3 January of this year, that a nuclear war cannot be fought, since it cannot be won.

The core concern about the humanitarian consequences of the use of nuclear weapons is enshrined in the Treaty of Tlatelolco, the NPT and the Comprehensive Nuclear Tests Ban Treaty, and is the rationale for the TPNW. It is not, therefore, a concept alien to the NPT and, as such, should be recognized by the Review Conference, as it did in 2010.

Mr. President,

Mexico will do everything in its power to ensure that this Conference concludes with a final agreement that includes the review of the implementation of the NPT, as well as prospective steps that, based on the agreements and obligations previously adopted, contributes to a safer and more peaceful world, based on international law and not on the state of terror of nuclear weapons.

Thank you very much.